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Difference and interference

On the reduction of hermeneutics to anthropology

GIANNI VATTIMO

In the final chapter of *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature*, Richard Rorty performs a dense critique of what he considers to be a mixture, in the thought of Habermas, of the point of view of anthropology and that of transcendental philosophy. The text to which Rorty refers is a page of the *Nachwort* to the second edition of *Erkenntnis und Interesse* (1973), in which Habermas writes: "The functions knowledge has in universal contexts of practical life can only be successfully analyzed in the framework of a reformulated transcendental philosophy. This, incidentally, does not entail an empiricist critique of the claim to absolute truth. As long as cognitive interests can be identified and analyzed through reflection upon the logic of inquiry in the natural and cultural sciences, they can legitimately claim a 'transcendental' status. They assume an 'empirical' status as soon as they are analyzed as the result of natural history — analyzed, as it were, in terms of cultural anthropology."¹ Rorty maintains that, contrary to what Habermas thinks, "there is no point in trying to find a general synoptic way of 'analyzing' the 'functions knowledge has in universal contexts of practical life,' " and that "cultural anthropology (in a large sense which includes intellectual history) is all we need."²

This critique of the, if you will, "transcendentalization" of anthropology, which seems also to me to be the implication of the most recent positions of Habermas (and also of Apel), might be a good starting point for a reflection on hermeneutics and anthropology.³ In fact, Rorty advances this critique within the framework of a basic acceptance of Heidegger's and Gadamer's thought, hence from a hermeneutic point of view. Rorty's critique attests to a tendency of hermeneutics to enter into a very close relationship with cultural anthropology: one might even say, to dissolve into it. It is true, as is well known, that Habermas and Apel also claim a continuity with Heideggerian hermeneutics. Apel, above

all, purports to free hermeneutics from its internal limits by relocating it in a theory of unlimited communication conceived as a sort of Kantian a priori. But to remain faithful to its Heideggerian origin, hermeneutics has to rebel against exactly this type of reassumption into a transcendental perspective. Kantianism and Neo-Kantianism are nothing less than instances of that metaphysical thinking that Heidegger had tried to supersede by conceiving of the finitude of *Da-sein* (There-being) in relation to *Geworfenheit* (Thrown-ness, the always radically contingent qualification of the project within which things are given to *Da-sein* as a world). In his later writings Heidegger no longer defines *Geworfenheit* in the rather abstract terms of *Being and Time*. He fills out the notion with the historically destined qualifications that became clear to him in his work of the thirties and that identify the thrownness of the project with its "disposition" in a historically determined language. In this sense *Geworfenheit* is precisely what discloses itself only to an anthropological analysis — in the broad yet very specific sense that Rorty gives to the term in the passage quoted above. If we take the historically destined thrownness of *Da-sein* seriously, and hence do not wish to construct a new metaphysical anthropology (a description of "essential" structures of human being), then we can only develop the discourse along the lines of cultural anthropology.

In emphasizing this inner tendency of hermeneutics to lead to cultural anthropology, Rorty indeed isolates one of the meanings that anthropology has assumed in the course of its history. It may be the one that is the most problematic and historically remote (as we shall see), but doubtless also the most characteristic. Cultural anthropology is conceived as a discourse on "other" cultures, and the anthropologist seems to be he who as it were "goes the furthest possible." It is likely that the other views of anthropological discourse in the history of our culture — as (b) the individuation of the most general communal structures of civilizations, and as (c) discourse on the archaic — are only derived from this first and fundamental meaning, which conceives of an encounter with "other" civilizations, and encounter that has become culturally most relevant in the modern age. This Otherness is in some way "regulated," and even exorcized, by way of (b): by a (metaphysically

1. Quoted in Richard Rorty, *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1979), p. 380.

2. *Ibid.*, p. 381.

3. I have discussed the Neo-Kantian implications in the thought of Habermas and Apel in *Al di là del soggetto* (Milan: Feltrinelli, 1981), pp. 69–84. For Apel, see especially *Transformation der Philosophie* (Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1973).

inspired) appeal to a common essence of man, to a suprahistorical structure within the limits of which all human phenomena, however different they seem, are contained. The idea of (c), of other cultures as primitive or archaic, appears in various historical forms either as an alternative to or as related to (b), the individuation of essential structures. The common human essence is thought to be discoverable only if one goes back beyond the historical differences that have removed us from it; or else, other cultures are seen as simply more primitive phases of a single true human civilization (which, incidentally, would be the civilization of the people for whom cultural anthropology has first acquired the status of a "scientific" discipline).

Whatever the historical relation between these three main configurations of cultural anthropology, hermeneutics, at least as Rorty sees it, gives a central and determinant place to the first: the one in which anthropology is a discourse on, or with, *other* cultures. This preference is legitimized — not only in Rorty but generally in contemporary thought — both by theoretical arguments tied to a certain conception of hermeneutics (to which I shall return in a moment) and, however implicitly, by the rather general relinquishment of the ethno- or Eurocentric prejudice at work not only in the more simplistic evolutionary views of the primitive but probably also in descriptively oriented ethnography and even in structural anthropology. On the one hand, a "description" of a culture cannot presume to be a neutral transcultural act, rooted as it is in our specifically European epistemological tradition; on the other, and even more clearly, the conceptual schemes on the basis of which such a "neutral" description of culture would develop (beginning, for instance, with the very structures of kinship) place in the foreground patterns and connections that are again basic to our own specific culture and experience.

Rorty's position with which we began not only favors a certain conception of anthropology. It also bases its choice upon a particular conception of hermeneutics that stands in need of clarification. For Rorty, hermeneutics is defined in opposition to epistemology. The main thrust of *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* consists in a critique of the foundational model of Western philosophy, which culminates, in the modern age, in a progressive identification of philosophy with epistemology (understood as a theory of foundational knowledge — founded, that is, in the mind's capacity to faithfully mirror nature, or at least to function according to a stable or natural scheme). Although Rorty oscillates

somewhat in his use of the term epistemology, the opposition on which he defines hermeneutics is clear. Epistemology is grounded on the assumption that all types of discourse are commensurable and translatable and that the foundation for their truth lies precisely in the translation into a basic language ultimately mirroring facts. Hermeneutics does not admit the givenness of such a unifying language. Instead of attempting to translate the language of the Other into its own, it tries to "appropriate" it. Hermeneutics is a bit like becoming acquainted with a person as opposed to knowing something through logically constructed demonstrations.

Epistemology and hermeneutics are not mutually exclusive, but — at least according to one of the meanings Rorty gives the terms — they are applied to different fields. Epistemology represents the discourse of Kuhn's "normal science," whereas hermeneutics stands for that of revolutionary science. "We will be epistemological," writes Rorty, "where we understand perfectly well what is happening but want to codify it in order to extend, or strengthen, or teach, or 'ground' it. We must be hermeneutical where we do not understand what is happening but are honest enough to admit it . . ." Hermeneutics is "discourse about as-yet-incommensurable discourses."⁴ From this it seems clear that, for Rorty, the typical hermeneutical situation is what in Quine's terms could be called a situation of "radical translation," even if it actually has less to do with translation than with an "assimilation" of the discourse of the Other, something closer to an intuitive act (which, raising questions I cannot deal with here, ties Rorty to a perhaps overly romantic view of hermeneutics).

With his emphasis on radical Otherness as the starting point of hermeneutical discourse, Rorty surely delineates one of the characteristic traits of the theory of interpretation. It can be maintained that, historically, hermeneutical theory becomes a specific discipline in European culture at the point when, with the rupture of Catholic unity, the problem of *Missverstehen* (misunderstanding) assumes decisive proportions socially and culturally (and an analogous process touches the relation to the classical tradition). In contemporary hermeneutical ontology, the centrality of the initial condition of *Missverstehen* is transformed into an actual conception of Being marked by traits of eventuality and Otherness. According to Heidegger, Being is given only in the form of ontological difference

4. *Philosophy*, pp. 321, 343.

(which he sometimes calls *Zweifalt*, “twofoldedness”): the idea is that Being is not identifiable with beings, with the particular entities given to us in our experience (things, facts, persons), but is rather comparable to the light by which entities become visible. Now, it is likely that the only way of experiencing ontological difference is in the encounter with the specific differences separating beings from each other. Indeed, it is impossible to experience Being itself as different from beings: this would amount to what Heidegger calls a “metaphysical” identification of Being with a specific entity (be it even the supreme being, or God). Presumably, the way in which Being as difference occurs in our experience is probably as the encounter with the other (being) as Other. Ontological difference can be experienced only as “interference,” or what amounts to the same thing, as dialogue. There is no other experience of Being, no other way in which it is given, but as the shock of the initial *Missverstehen* experienced in the encounter with Otherness.

This identification of difference with interference, which is never explicit in Heidegger but which can be inferred from his writings, may be the prime justification for the transformation of hermeneutics into cultural anthropology that Rorty advances. Nevertheless, this transformation entails several problems. First, it is not so self-evident that anthropology is really the science of the Otherness of cultures that Rorty, with some good reasons, assumes it to be. This is not simply a matter of theoretical distinctions, as if one wanted to show that hermeneutics is not X but Y, that anthropology is not C but D. More likely we are confronted with a certain *Wesen* of each discipline. To recognize that this *Wesen* may not coincide with the definitions on which the discourse has been based means much more than a correction of a theoretical error. It confronts us with a trait of *Geschick*.⁵

Against the framework established by Rorty stands a

5. As is well known, Heidegger emphasizes the verbal significance of the word *Wesen*, which means “essence” but which has the form of an infinitive: thus, “to essentialize.” As a verbal, *Wesen* suggests that the essence of a thing consists only in the way it is given in our particular epoch of being, in its current “way of coming to be.” *Geschick*, which Heidegger spells *Ge-schick*, means the “destiny” of a particular epoch or historical humanity as determined by tradition (and thus not by an a priori structure, nature, or essence). Since *schicken* means “to send,” *Ge-schick* can be translated as “mittence,” the term proposed by William J. Richardson in his classic work *Heidegger: Through Phenomenology to Thought* (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1963). Richardson’s book provides the best background, in English, to the aspects of Heidegger’s thought explored in this essay.

series of difficulties with regard to hermeneutics. Let us address these by taking up one of the clearest points from the dialogue with the Japanese that Heidegger published in *On the Way to Language*.⁶ This dialogue is especially pertinent, for in it Heidegger is perhaps most directly involved in a transcultural effort, in a sort of anthropological adventure. One of Heidegger’s themes is that such a dialogue with other cultures is threatened in its very possibility by the “complete Europeanization of the Earth and of man” (*die vollständige Europäisierung der Erde und des Menschen*). The consequence is that “blindness grows,” risking to destroy and to silence “all that is essential in its sources” (*alles Wesenhafte in seinen Quellen*) — that is, every originary occurrence in *Wesen*.

The anthropologist is becoming increasingly aware of a condition that belongs to the very roots of anthropology but that today has reached a peak: the complete occidentalization of the world. This does not necessarily mean, as we shall see, that other cultures have totally disappeared. Occidentalization has occurred primarily through political domination and, above all, through the diffusion of cultural models. Along with political and cultural domination goes a more scientific and methodological domination, one that approaches the so-called primitive societies as objects of a knowledge based entirely on “occidental” categories. Of course, this detracts in no way from the scientific nature of cultural anthropology. On the contrary, only the application of such deeply occidental categories makes anthropology a science — that is, an aspect of the metaphysical endeavor to reduce the world to some measurable objectivity. Yet this very consideration raises doubts as to the possibility of conceiving anthropology as a discourse on other cultures, even if it in no way reduces the scientific validity of anthropological field work; precisely by being framed within a metaphysical-scientific conceptualism, it is clearly distinguished from exotic curiosity, from that flight of individual intuition with its dreamy, somnolent taste for magical horizons. (Tour guides operate in the same rationalizing way, allowing one to waste no time. One tends to say: “I did Greece this year.”)

If these considerations hold true, the conception of anthropology as an encounter with the other as *other* becomes increasingly problematic. The condition in which the anthropologist initiates a “dialogue” with the

6. Martin Heidegger, “A Dialogue on Language,” in *On the Way to Language*, trans. Peter D. Hertz (New York: Harper & Row, 1971), pp. 1–54.

alien culture is always already determined by a preestablished distribution of roles (the colonial or postcolonial situation, etc.) that seems to exclude the possibility of "radical translation." Incidentally, this fact probably also reduces, or perhaps completely cancels, the difference between a "classical" and an "ethnographical" hermeneutics. This difference seems to be predicated on the distinction between the interpretation of a "text" (classical hermeneutics dealing with texts inside our own tradition) and the encounter with a "context" (the totality of an alien culture) that does not belong to an already given totality encompassing both us and it. Yet even a relation to the alien culture presupposes a given "context" — precisely the situation in which the anthropologist and the anthropologist's "object" become accessible to each other (concretely, the colonial-scientific situation in which most anthropology has worked until now). From this point of view, different as the specific methodologies may be, classical and ethnographical hermeneutics do not appear to be basically heterogeneous.

The idea of anthropology as a discipline involving a dialogue with other cultures in their Otherness here appears to be merely an "ideal," or even an ideological fiction, created to balance a situation in which Otherness actually tends to dissolve through the intensifying occidentalization of the world.

A similar doubt as to the existence of actual Otherness can be found even in philosophical hermeneutics. It is true that hermeneutical thinkers such as Gadamer or, more recently, Rorty tend to emphasize almost exclusively the difference between the interlocutors in the hermeneutical dialogue (thus opening the way to the ultimate dissolution of hermeneutics into cultural anthropology). Heidegger himself, on the other hand, to whom hermeneutics owes its philosophical foundations, shows a much keener awareness of the element of "identity," or better, "sameness" (*das Selbe, Selbigkeit*) that is involved in all dialogue and especially in man's experience today. In the essay "Hölderlin and the Essence of Poetry," which inaugurates his more mature meditation on Being, language, and dialogue, Heidegger insists not only on the difference between Being and beings (the ontological difference) and between the interlocutors, but just as much on the unity presupposed by all dialogue.⁷ In commenting on Hölderlin's lines *Viel hat*

erfahren der Mensch / Der Himmlischen viele genannt, / Seit ein Gespräch wir sind / Und hören können voneinander (Much has man experienced / Many of the heavenly ones has he named, / Since we are a dialogue / And have been able to hear from one another), he emphasized the *ein*, which therefore we should probably translate as "one": dialogue can be a dialogue only on the basis of a unity that makes it possible.

It would be oversimplifying to see the relation between the difference of the interlocutors and the unity of the dialogue as that of initial and final moments of the hermeneutical process: difference and separation characterizing the beginning of the dialogue, and unity the end of it. In fact, the very notion of a hermeneutical circle — always a central theme in hermeneutics — reflects the common understanding that the beginning of a dialogue *presupposes* a preliminary unity between the partners.

The question of the connection, or possible contradiction, between Sameness and Eventuality (or novelty) in Heidegger's notion of Being is extremely important, because the essence of the objections Heidegger raises against traditional metaphysics is that such metaphysics has always conceived Being in terms of permanent structures, in such a way identifying it with an (ever-)present being, be it even the supreme being of God. The term *Ereignis* (Event), used by Heidegger "to indicate" (not "to define") Being in his last works, is meant to mark this new ontological approach, which excludes all essentialist views of Being. The *Ereignis*, or Eventual, character of Being is given in the dialogical essence of history. Being is nothing but the disclosure of historicolinguistic horizons within which "beings" (things, men, etc.) come into presence; these horizons are linked to one another in an appeal-response connection. The general experiential traits of historical humanity are written in the language it speaks; this language is not the actualization of an a priori structure (in a Cartesian or Kantian sense) but the *je und je* (from time to time) differing response of historical man to the heritage he receives from the past, to *Überlieferung* ("trans-mission," which is also the meaning of *Ge-schick*, "mittence").

What does *das Selbe* — "Sameness" — mean, in relation to *Ereignis*, that is, to the Eventuality of Being? This question cannot be posed and resolved by itself, as an abstract theoretical matter; the very fact that it is posed — or, more generally, that philosophy, in Heidegger's work, discovers the *Ereignis* character of Being — is in its turn an event within the history of

7. In *Existence and Being*, ed. Werner Brock (Chicago: Henry Regnery Company, 1949), pp. 270–92.

Being. In other words, the connection between Event (or Otherness) and Sameness in Heidegger's ontology and in hermeneutics can be understood only if we take into account another point: the relation between the hermeneutical emphasis on Sameness and the actual unification of the earth through the universal occidentalization of mankind.

If we see this connection — Eventuality, Sameness, and the occidentalization of mankind — we shall no doubt realize that hermeneutics is not primarily the philosophy of an ideal dialogue, one that would oppose to the earth's increasing homogenization an ideal of conserving or restoring the plurality of cultures, thought to be the only possible condition for an authentic ontological (i.e., dialogical) experience. Hermeneutic ontology — at least in Heidegger, though not so much in authors such as Gadamer or Rorty (which might be a symptom of remarkable differences within the Heideggerian tradition) — is deeply concerned with the problems raised by the universal occidentalization of the earth, but *not only*, or primarily, because it sees this process as a loss or impoverishment of an "authentic" condition of dialogue, to be regretted and possibly restored. When, in *Identity and Difference*,⁸ Heidegger writes that *Ge-stell* (a term I propose to translate by "imposition," and which for Heidegger means the totality of the scientificotechnological organization of the modern world) is not only the supreme threat to human essence, but may also be a "first shining of *Ereignis*," he means that there may be a positive connection between the occidentalization of the earth and the overcoming of metaphysics through a new ontological thinking. As a matter of fact, one could legitimately maintain that whereas hermeneutics as a *technical* discipline originates in an age when the Christian unity of Europe is broken (during the Reformation) and at a time when the West first conceptualizes the problem of its relation to other civilizations, hermeneutics as a *philosophical* discipline develops at a later stage (the nineteenth to twentieth centuries), which is no longer one of radical Otherness, but rather of an increasing unification of cultures. Although this fact in itself proves nothing, it may inform the connection, on which Heidegger meditates over and over, between the retrieval of Being as *Ereignis* (and dialogue) and the accomplishment of metaphysics through the total domination of the scientificotechnological organization of the world.

8. *Identität und Differenz* (Pfullingen: Neske, 1957), p. 27. In English: *Identity and Difference*, trans. Joan Stambaugh (New York: Harper & Row, 1969).

It may be, therefore, that what hermeneutics experiences in anthropology is not the discovery of a radical Otherness (that of different cultures) that would actualize the Eventual-dialogical nature of Being, but just the contrary: the discovery that Otherness is an ideological illusion. This is indeed a delusion, but it dialectically brings about a maturation: hermeneutics seeks out anthropology as a discourse on — or with — Otherness, yet anthropology actually no longer conceives itself as a setting for Otherness but rather as an internal aspect of the general process of occidentalization and homogenization, a process that appears as a loss only from the point of view of an ideal that is itself ideological. For hermeneutics, the experience of anthropology acts as an appeal to meditate less emphatically, or less "metaphysically," on the problems brought to light by the connection between Being as Event, Sameness, and the occidentalization of the world. Although it set out to seek in anthropology an ideal setting for the verification of its own concept of Being as Eventuality and Otherness, hermeneutics now finds itself sent back to meditate on the meaning of Sameness and its connection with the metaphysical homogenization of the world.

This connection, in turn, is just as ambiguous as the experience of anthropologists who would like to refute both the evolutionary (ethno- or Eurocentric) point of view and the illusion of a possible dialogue or play of different cultures. We might say that this connection is "that which remains to be thought," that which even anthropology itself, though not merely as a repetitive confirmation, forces us to see. To the idea of anthropology as a scientific description of the constants of culture, conditioned by the metaphysical notion of science and, more concretely, by the occidental domination of the planet, one cannot oppose an ideal of anthropology as the setting for an authentic encounter with the Other. This would amount to an overly simplistic and optimistic identification of anthropology as the heir of philosophy in the wake of the end of metaphysics and the rise of the hermeneutical perspective. A hermeneutical philosophy that conceives of its task in these terms does not take into account the ambiguity of anthropology's own self-consciousness. Above all, it abandons its specific theoretical task, which involves a much more complex interweaving of Eventuality, Otherness, and Sameness, one that requires as well a less superficial consideration of the metaphysical homogenization of the world.

Besides this reminder of the connection between Eventuality and Sameness, the dialogue between hermeneutics and anthropology may have something else to offer. If, in fact, we do succeed in understanding what happens to the object of anthropology in the general context of the homogenization of the planet (a context, we must recall, in which even the descriptive scientificity of the discipline has been shown to be irremediably tied up with both the horizon of metaphysics and the occidental domination of the world), we may also obtain — like Heidegger in his dialogue with the Japanese — some indication of the way in which to exercise hermeneutical thought in the era of the end of metaphysics.

As a starting point I shall take a short text by Remo Guidieri.⁹ Unlike what most philosophers (and above all Heidegger) think about the forms of occidentalization of the planet, Guidieri points out that occidentalization entails more than the mere disappearance of other cultures:

Those who have cried out at the death of cultures neither knew how, nor wanted, to see that these very cultures, obsessed like our own by the myth of abundance, yet have produced their own specific ways of fitting into the occidental universe. As paradoxical, irrational, or even burlesque as these ways may be, they are as authentic as ancient habits — tributaries as they are of the cultural forms from which they draw their possibility. The nonoccidental contemporary world is an immense warehouse of residues in conditions that have yet to be analyzed.

Although it acknowledges this situation, ethnology also shows, in some of its procedures, the (ideologically conditioned) tendency to deny this world of residues as an object of its study. Rather, it continues to idealize the specter of the purely primitive, which it has constructed as “the bearer of the values that it [anthropology] itself nourishes and defends” (and which are indeed missing in the occident): “moderation, order, security, parsimony, and so on.” Such ethnology is concerned with the defense of the authenticity of alien cultures, believing that in so doing it is upholding their

“traditional” values. Yet what we are really faced with is rather a series of contemporary “derivations” of primitivism, “hybrid forms . . . , residues contaminated by modernity, margins of the present that embrace both the society of the Third World and also the ghettos of industrial society.”

This may be the most that hermeneutics can reap from a dialogue with anthropology: a decisive modification of the somewhat conventional image (with such illustrious fathers as Spengler, Weber, and Gehlen) of the Europeanization of the planet in the era of the triumph of metaphysics. What faces us is an enormous “warehouse of residues,” which, by interacting with the unequal distribution of power and resources on a planetary level, gives rise to the growth of marginal situations that represent *the truth of the primitive in our world*. The hermeneutical (and also anthropological) illusion of encountering the Other, with all its theoretical emphases, must come to terms with a mixed reality in which Otherness is consumed: consumed not in favor of some imaginary total organization but in that of a state of diffuse contaminations. This state — rather than that of Europe at the time of the rupture of traditional Christian unity, in which hermeneutics first became a technical discipline — may be the one in which hermeneutics develops into an *ontology*. The questions we have raised as to the possible connection between the Sameness in hermeneutical dialogue and the metaphysical homogenization of the earth must address this situation, if only because one of the two terms to be thought, namely homogenization, is transformed. In my opinion, this transformation is decisive: in the horizon of an ontology of eventuality and Otherness, the only form of Sameness that one can admit without falling back on a metaphysical identification of Being with a type of being is precisely this debilitated or contaminated Sameness — in any event certainly not the ironclad unity of the total organization of the technological-metaphysical world, nor however some other, “authentic” unity diametrically opposed to it. In the self-consciousness of contemporary cultural anthropology, which confronts the marginality of the primitive (and of every “alien” culture), we may be witnessing the ambiguity of Heidegger’s *Ge-stell* (im-position), a place both of extreme danger and also of the first shining of *Ereignis*.

On the basis of these suggestions, offered by anthropological activity and admittedly treated in very general terms, we can return to Heidegger’s dialogue with the Japanese, where the effort to think without

9. “Les sociétés primitives aujourd’hui,” in *Philosopher: les interrogations contemporaines*, ed. Ch. Delacampagne and R. Maggioni (Paris: Fayard, 1980). This essay is a particularly good point of reference, for it expresses ideas and orientations largely shared by contemporary anthropologists. As for the problem of the “marginality” of “ethnographical” cultures in the contemporary world, especially in relation to the need for identity, see Francesco Pellizzi, “Misioneros y cargos: notas sobre identidad y aculturación en los altos de Chiapas,” *América indígena* (Mexico), 42 / 1.

falling into the trap of metaphysics is figured as a repudiation of concepts and signs, and rather as an attempt to follow *Winke* and *Gebärde*, “hints” and “gestures.” Yet metaphysical thinking still imposes itself as to a certain extent “inevitable.” In relation to it, following hints appears to be a *Seitenpfad*, a “bypath.” All the efforts in search of nonmetaphysical modes of meaning (which cannot be signs in the sense of *blosse Bezeichnung*, “mere denotation”), which occupy so many pages of *On the Way to Language*, appear, in light of what has been said so far, clearly irreducible to what sometimes seems to be a Heideggerian taste for mysticism. Nor, for that matter, can they be referred back to a strong conception of *Selbigkeit*, “Sameness,” which would let itself be perceived only in signs, as the other, “authentic” pole, opposed to the inauthenticity of the “desertification” of the world by the West. Hints and gestures — and here it is unnecessary to stick to the letter of Heidegger’s texts — are the modes of significance corresponding to a world in which, given the ambiguity of *Ge-stell*, the Sameness of ontological *Geschick* and the late-metaphysical homogenization of mankind as a huge “warehouse of residues” are less and less distinguishable from each other and *in their union* constitute *Geschick* proper — the destiny and “mittence” in which Being, dissolving its own strongly marked Sameness, truly takes leave of metaphysics and to some extent of itself.

In such a world the difficulty encountered for instance in still distinguishing classical and ethnographical hermeneutics is shown to be something other than a theoretical difficulty. It too is a trait of destiny. Just as the “radical Otherness” of other cultures is shown to be a probably never-realized ideal (and certainly unrealizable for us), so in the process of homogenized contamination even the texts that belong to our tradition — the “classics” in the literal sense of the word, on the basis of which one has always measured our civilization — progressively lose their cogency as models and enter into the big “warehouse of residues”. The risk exists that one may exaggerate and mythologize this process out of a love for theory; yet these are its main lines. It needs to be studied more carefully. First, however, it must be recognized.

The problematic treated by Nietzsche in the second *Untimely Meditation* — aside from its conclusions,

which Nietzsche himself questioned in later years — appears here to be decisive for determining the historically destined setting of European culture. The great “warehouse of residues” is not so different from that storehouse of theatrical costumes to which Nietzsche compares the “garden of history” in which nineteenth-century man roams, encountering no strong identity but only the availability of “masks.” The analogy, against what one would expect, does not imply any “Dionysiac” characteristics. The world of man in our time appears more and more as a theatrical storehouse, but without any ludic or aesthetic implications. On the contrary, the theatrical storehouse is a “warehouse of residues.” In such a world there is no “iron cage” (as Weber called it) of total technological organization nor a pure “glorification of the simulacres,” which Deleuze has imagined in *Différence et répétition* and in other works.¹⁰ The world of ontological hermeneutics is simply a world of nihilism in action, where Being has a chance of occurring as authentic only in the form of impoverishment — not the poverty of asceticism, governed by the myth of ultimately discovering a splendid kernel of true value, but the poverty of the marginal-inconspicuous,¹¹ of lived contamination as the only way out of the dreams, however camouflaged, of metaphysics. (Could even the Cargo Cult be a “first shining of *Ereignis*”?)

Anthropology, like hermeneutics, is neither an encounter with radical Otherness nor a scientific “systematization” of the human phenomenon in terms of structures. It probably will return to its form of a dialogue with the archaic (the third of the conceptions that have historically defined it in our culture), but in the only way in which the *arche* is given in the era of completed metaphysics: that of residues, marginality, and contamination.

(Translated by Thomas J. Harrison)

10. Giles Deleuze, *Différence et répétition* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1968).

11. Here I am referring to Heidegger’s use of the word *gering* (inconspicuous, unpretentious) in the last page of the essay “Das Ding,” in *Vorträge und Aufsätze* (Pfullingen: Neske, 1954). In English: “The Thing,” in *Poetry, Language, Thought*, trans. Albert Hofstadter (New York: Harper & Row, 1971), p. 182.